



Bhojpuri Plot

RAVI KISHEN AND NAGMA
SHOOT FOR A BHOJPURI FILM
IN RAJPIPLA

Rajpipla in southern Gujarat's Satpura range has become to Bhojpuri and Gujarati films what Switzerland was to Bollywood

|By Uday Mahurkar|

A cinematic revolution of sorts has taken root in the Satpura ranges of southern Gujarat. The language is Bhojpuri, and the budgets are low, but Rajpipla, the shooting star of this new wonderland, couldn't be a happier place.

Scenic Rajpipla, not too far from the Narmada dam, has a charm that reflects its good old days of royalty. But now, Rajpipla's latest avatar of *desi* Switzerland for outdoor and indoor shoots of low-budget Bhojpuri and Gujarati films as well as TV serials is giving its residents reasons to smile.

Harji Vasava, 32, a poor farm labourer from a village near Rajpipla, used to struggle to survive earlier but now makes up to Rs 150 a day for eight months in a year working as an extra in film shoots. Bhikhabhai Rathod is one step higher in the low-budget film food chain: he makes up to Rs 500 a day as an organiser for film units. Earlier, he would do part-time jobs with local businessmen.

Rajpipla's grocery stores are no less pleased by this celluloid harvest that has seen their sales go up in the past few years. Private vehicle owners

in the town too are raking it in during these times. Five years ago, the number of private vehicles being hired for a day's use was 20; it's almost 90 now. The urge to make money has become stronger than ever. Rathod was surprised a couple of years ago when people from Vavdi village near Rajpipla demanded Rs 2,500 a day from film units for shooting in the village.

For low-budget filmmakers, shooting in Rajpipla is about 40 per cent cheaper than in and around Mumbai. It's just 60 km from Bharuch, a mainline railway station on the Delhi-